comfortable with. At these meetings, he would try and pin me down to specific actions and time frame. I would go as far as indicating the general direction in which I would go but refused to get committed to any specifics. There were no overt arguments between us, but it was clear that Chidambaram was annoyed that I was not moving as aggressively as he would have liked me to. Our relationship remained frosty.

There was one particular meeting sometime in late November 2008, larger and more formal than usual, chaired by the prime minister and also involving a dozen Cabinet ministers and secretaries to the government. The agenda was to discuss the government's response to the crisis, and I too was invited. By then, Chidambaram had moved from finance to home ministry, a transfer occasioned by the terrorist attacks in Mumbai, but he was also invited to the meeting to get the benefit of his advice.

The meeting kept clear of monetary or regulatory issues, but several ministers and secretaries took advantage of my presence and the pressure of the crisis to ask that the Reserve Bank open money spigots for all sorts of sectors and schemes, much of which had no relevance to fighting the crisis. I was amused by this attempt to use the crisis as a cover to get the Reserve Bank to relax its norms and support proposals that it had consistently resisted.

In some sense, this was vigorous democracy at play and, in fact, mirrored what was happening in another big democracy, the US. There were headline media reports on how US lawmakers were playing pork-barrel politics while debating their President's fiscal package in the Congress. They were tearing apart the package to include their own pet schemes to serve narrow constituency interests as a precondition for their support, never mind that all the pork barrelling may have compromised the basic thrust of the scheme of boosting consumer demand.

I had to say no to almost all of these proposals even as I found it difficult to disagree with friends and colleagues who were all well intentioned, but not necessarily well informed on what the Reserve Bank can or cannot do. When the meeting concluded well past 10 p.m., and all of us stood up waiting for the prime minister to leave, I recall the prime minister coming